

Especially useful is LibreOffice: a productivity suite containing word processing, spreadsheet and other office applications; Inkscape and GIMP, which are well-known and mature free software graphics tools; Firefox, the world-famous Web browser; and the newest version of the desktop publishing program, Scribus, apart from a wide range of communications and information security apps.

LibreOffice 3.5 has a lot of new improvements over earlier versions. These include a more sophisticated handling of document headers and footers, a faster English grammar checker, and new compatibility with Microsoft Visio files.

Several VALO-CD programs have been included and updated in the collection since 2008. However, this year, a new program has qualified for inclusion. MuseScore is a free software cross-platform music notation program, which is a powerful alternative to expensive proprietary competitors like Sibelius, Finale, and Capella.

VALO-CD also contains detailed user guides to make it easier to get started. The manuals are written by the FLOSS Manuals documentation community. "Our aim is to make it easy for the users to get into open source software. Even the manuals themselves are written collaboratively and distributed freely," says Tomi Toivio, the administrator of the Finnish language FLOSS Manuals.

'Free Your Android!' campaign from FSFE

A campaign called 'Free Your Android!' has been launched by the Free Software Foundation Europe (FSFE). This would help in creating a free software Android ecosystem, right from the ROMs, tablets and smartphones, to the applications which run on the operating system.

According to the campaign sources, with Carrier IQ logging user information, telecom carriers now have access to information without the user's knowledge. Carriers also have access to the applications, which upload contacts. In such cases, users would benefit only if they use a device that runs on free software. The campaign's Web page states, "Even though you may not have the skills to directly exercise all of your freedom, you will benefit from a vibrant community that can do it together." The main aim of the campaign is to free both the operating system and the applications. The suggestions given by the campaign for an operating system that are 100 per cent free Android include Replicant OS, even though it only runs on a few devices, or CyanogenMod which runs on many more devices. The campaign advises users that free software downloads from the Android Market are not completely trustworthy and should not be used. It offers the F-Droid project to its users, which has a repository of free and safe applications that can be downloaded easily.



Tizen SDK Beta released

The Tizen Association has released the Tizen SDK Beta and Source Code Updates. Tizen, the successor of MeeGo, has taken over from MeeGo, which could not fare too well despite continuous efforts from Intel and Nokia to build this Linux-based smartphone OS.

With this beta, the Tizen Association encourages developers to start working with the new features and functionality in order to provide feedback that can be used to improve Tizen during the final stages of its development.

The Tizen SDK and API will help developers use HTML 5 and other related

Mozilla's mobile OS can make smartphones cheaper!

Mozilla, which is doing very well with its free Web browser, Firefox, now aims to repeat history with its new open source operating system for mobiles that could slash the prices of smartphones drastically.

Mozilla is currently working on a project dubbed as 'Boot to Gecko', which will compete with Google's Android operating system and



Apple's iOS. With the help of this OS, OEMs will be able to generate smartphones that will be almost '10 times cheaper' than an iPhone. If you are wondering if there will be a trade-off in the features, the OS promises to offer an experience comparable to the other 'expensive' smartphones.

Mozilla's upcoming OS will have all the smartphones' capabilities like calls, messaging, and browsing functions. But since it will all be Web-based, there will be no need for much of the intermediary software that requires a large memory or speedy processors that make smartphones so expensive. Therefore, Mozilla will be able to slash the price of its smartphones considerably.

The company has joined hands with Telefonica for this project and aims to ship phones running on the new OS this year.